

Find out more

THERE IS A WEALTH OF INFORMATION available about the oceans and marine life—so it is easy to find out more about them even if you do not live (or go on vacation) near the sea. The first stop should be an aquarium. Many have impressive exhibits of sea creatures displayed in their natural settings, so you can see the inhabitants of a coral reef, a mangrove, or the open ocean up close. Watch, also, for excellent wildlife programs on television, or search the Internet using the Web sites listed below as a starting point.



Razor shell encrusted with barnacles, oyster (behind) and slipper limpet

SEA SHELLS

If you visit the beach, look for seashells washed up on the shore. Take along a guidebook to help you identify them. Always put inhabited shells back where you find them, however, and never collect shells from a protected site. Many reefs, such as Australia's Great Barrier Reef, are conservation zones, and removing shells can damage the ecosystem.



VISIT AN AQUARIUM

Plan a visit to an aquarium to observe a huge range of marine life from all over the world's oceans. Many large aquariums have impressive viewing tanks containing hundreds of species, from jellyfish and giant octopuses to sharks and starfish. Some tanks are spread over several levels; others have transparent tunnels so you can walk right underneath the water. Watch for special events when you can get up close to sharks, rays, and other marine creatures.

USEFUL WEB SITES

- Join research scientists on an underwater exploration: www.at-sea.org
- Visit the coastal Louisiana site for quizzes, tips on identifying birds, and a coloring book: www.lacoast.gov/education/kids
- Download your own tidepool flashcards, as well as printouts on ocean topics for grades K–12: www.mms.gov/mmskids
- Homepage of Monterey Bay Aquarium with web cams: www.mbayaq.org/

STUDY A TIDE POOL

Tide pools are filled with a wide variety of plants and animals. Even if you visit the same pool several times, it is unlikely you will find the same creatures, making these habitats endlessly fascinating, dynamic environments to study. Look for starfish, anemones, mussels, and seaweed such as sea lettuce and kelp. If you stand very still, you may also spot crabs hiding in crevices between rocks, or a tiny fish.